

UTT Chapter 05 Assignment

Hey friend!

My life has been pretty crazy over the last few weeks! Midterms are intense around here, even though I'm only a freshman. For some reason, the teachers think it's okay if they assign a bunch of homework on top of all the studying we have to do for their midterms! I think one of my most difficult classes is gonna be economics. We have to know quite a few of the major economists in addition to what their contributions were. I have trouble keeping their names and dates straight. We also have to know a bunch of equations and graphs. It will be rough.

My last Econ class was really interesting though. We talked about the effects of price ceilings and floors on supply and demand. Apparently, if the government places a ceiling, or a maximum legal price for a good, in a market where the actual value of that product is more than the ceiling, it creates all kinds of problems. The demand will exceed the supply, and a shortage will occur. Sometimes black markets even result. Then with price floors, such as minimum wage, lots of people lose their jobs because companies can't afford to hire as many people since their skills are not worth the price set by the floor. If that whole discussion confuses you, you're not alone. I think I have a grasp on the general idea, but the specifics can get kind of confusing for me.

We did have an interesting discussion about all that in class though, which is why I told you about it. There's a guy in my class named Mark, and he disagreed with most of what the professor has said so far. During this last discussion, he kept piping up and saying things like, "If we just made it to where everyone earned the same amount of money, we wouldn't have problems with price floors and minimum wage." And "I don't see the problem with ceilings. If the government mandated that all producers had to set their prices the same, we'd get rid of all these supply and demand complications, and capitalists wouldn't take everyone's money because of unfair pricing!"

He keeps talking about this guy named Lenin. I totally embarrassed myself by saying, "Wait, I didn't know John Lennon was an economist!" Everyone laughed at me. Apparently it's a different Lenin . . . shows how much I know. He also quotes someone named "Marx" who apparently formulated a whole worldview called "Marxism." I'm assuming you've heard of this guy. **What does Marxism teach?** I'm guessing there is more to it than just economics. **What does Marxism say about humanity?** And **what does Marxism say is wrong with us?** Finally, **what does Marxism say about how we should live?**

Thanks so much for helping me with my questions . . . again! I feel like I can speak more intelligently with my friends after I get your letters back. I look forward to your answers on this one!

Gotta go! Bye!

-Doug

Doug brought up four different questions; below is a rough outline of possible responses:

1. What does Marxism teach?

The over-arching Marxist narrative promotes the overthrow of business owners through class struggle and revolution. When the exploited are overthrown, the exploited will be freed. Essentially, Marxism sees two forces at play in this world: dialectical materialism and economic determinism.

- a) **Dialectic materialism** is the formal name for the philosophy that posits a materialistic world incrementally progressing through socio-economic struggles toward the end goal of communism. As Marx saw it, reality was merely matter. In addition to matter, he believed that a force was working behind the scenes of nature to advance the cause of the poor. According to Marx, the dialectic is the process of inevitable conflicts between a thesis and antithesis that eventually brings about some type of synthesis. As conflicts arise and are resolved, society advances in favor of the synthesis. Today's synthesis becomes tomorrow's thesis, which conflicts with a new antithesis. The process repeats until communism eventually becomes the final synthesis.
- b) **Economic determinism** is the idea that history is the struggle towards the inevitable state of communism. To a Marxist, every event in history can be explained by the economic struggle between exploiters (**bourgeoisie**) and the exploited (**proletariat**).

These ideas form the basis of the communist economic policy. According to Marxism, socialism is the next step in our economic progression. Socialism includes heavy taxation, government takeover of businesses, and the elimination of laws protecting private property. Eventually, even the government will no longer be necessary and will simply cease to exist. When the communist utopia arrives, all things will be equal, we will share things in common, and each one will have according to his or her needs. [5.3]

2. What does Marxism say about human nature?

Marxism asserts that everything in nature is material, and human beings are simply part of this physical existence. We are merely matter in motion—just highly reflective, evolving animals. As we evolve, the poor among us evolve in their understanding of their place in society. The proletariat grows in their **class consciousness** and becomes increasingly aware of their oppression by the bourgeoisie. As the oppressed become more aware of their predicament, their understanding of morality evolves as well. **Proletariat morality** justifies whatever actions are deemed necessary to overthrow all existing oppressive social conditions. It erases any sense of mercy toward to the

bourgeoisie and dictates that the proletariat eliminate any person or thing that stands in opposition to the moral advance of communism. [5.6b]

3. What does Marxism say is wrong with us?

Marxism rejects the Christian view that human beings are all sinful creatures desperately in need of a savior. According to Marxism, the problem with society is economical. Property owners exploit the property-less workers. While most of society labors for a living, a small majority controls the means of labor and the labors. For Marxists, we are our own redeemers. It is up to the proletariat to save themselves from their exploiters. Salvation is achieved when communism is brought to fruition. If the proletariat want salvation, they must take the necessary steps to overthrow the bourgeoisie. [5.6c]

4. What does Marxism say about how we should live?

Marxists see the march towards socialism, and eventually communism, as a historical inevitability. Reflecting upon history, Marxists see a slow and progressive social evolution leading humanity away from economic tyranny and toward a future economic utopia. Although this process is inevitable, Marxism contends that we can, and should, help this process along. The members of the proletariat who realize their lot in life should join the revolution, promote the cause, and recruit fellow comrades. It is the duty of the proletariat to overthrow the oppressive government, establish socialism, abolish private property, and eliminate class divisions. As socialism takes root, oppression will fade, the government will dissolve, and communism will win the day. [5.6d]